Where you're pronounced is not where you are

Rules of argument incorporation in West Circassian nominalizations

Ksenia Ershova

University College London
(k.ershova@ucl.ac.uk)

25 February 2026
Surrey Linguistics Circle

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The premise: Contradictory argument hierarchies

Various parts of the West Circassian grammar are sensitive to different argument hierarchies:

- Reciprocals and parasitic gaps: syntactic ergativity

  $\boxed{\text{S/O}(\textsc{abs}) > \text{A}(\textsc{erg}) > \text{IO}}$ $\rightsquigarrow$ "surface subjecthood"

  subject $>$ **agent** $>$ **indirect object**

- Reflexives and obligatory control: syntactic accusativity

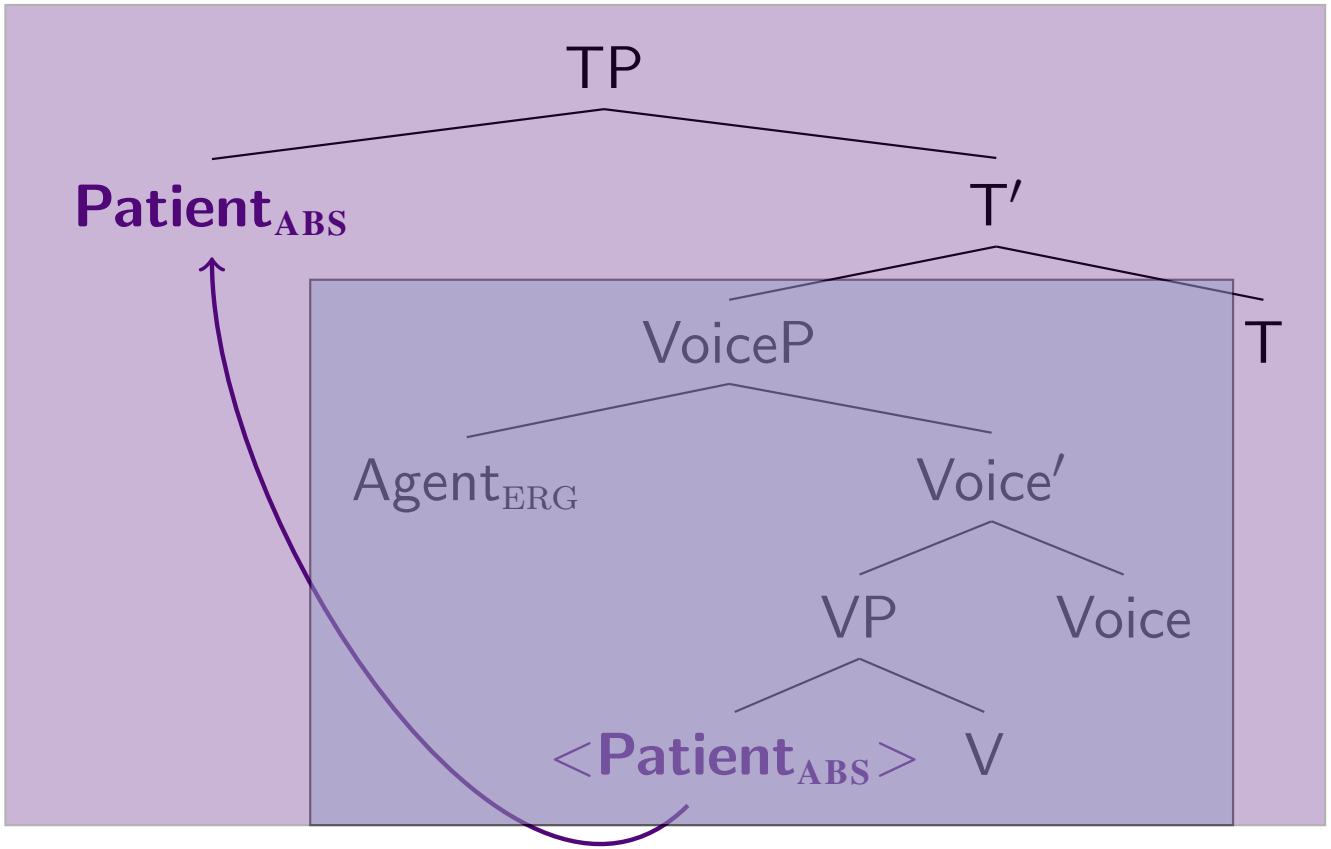
  $\boxed{\text{A}(\textsc{erg})+\text{S}(\textsc{abs}) > \text{O}(\textsc{abs})/\text{IO}}$ $\rightsquigarrow$ thematic hierarchy

  agent $>$ **patient/theme/goal/etc.**

A movement-based explanation

Ershova (2019, 2021, 2023, 2025):

- tree-geometric analysis
- different asymmetries result from movement



reciprocals
parasitic gaps

reflexives
control

(Aldridge 2008; Baker 1997; Bittner and Hale 1996; Manning 1996; Yuan 2018, 2022; Coon, Baier, and T. Levin 2021; Royer 2025, a.o.)

The puzzle: Hierarchy clash in nominalizations

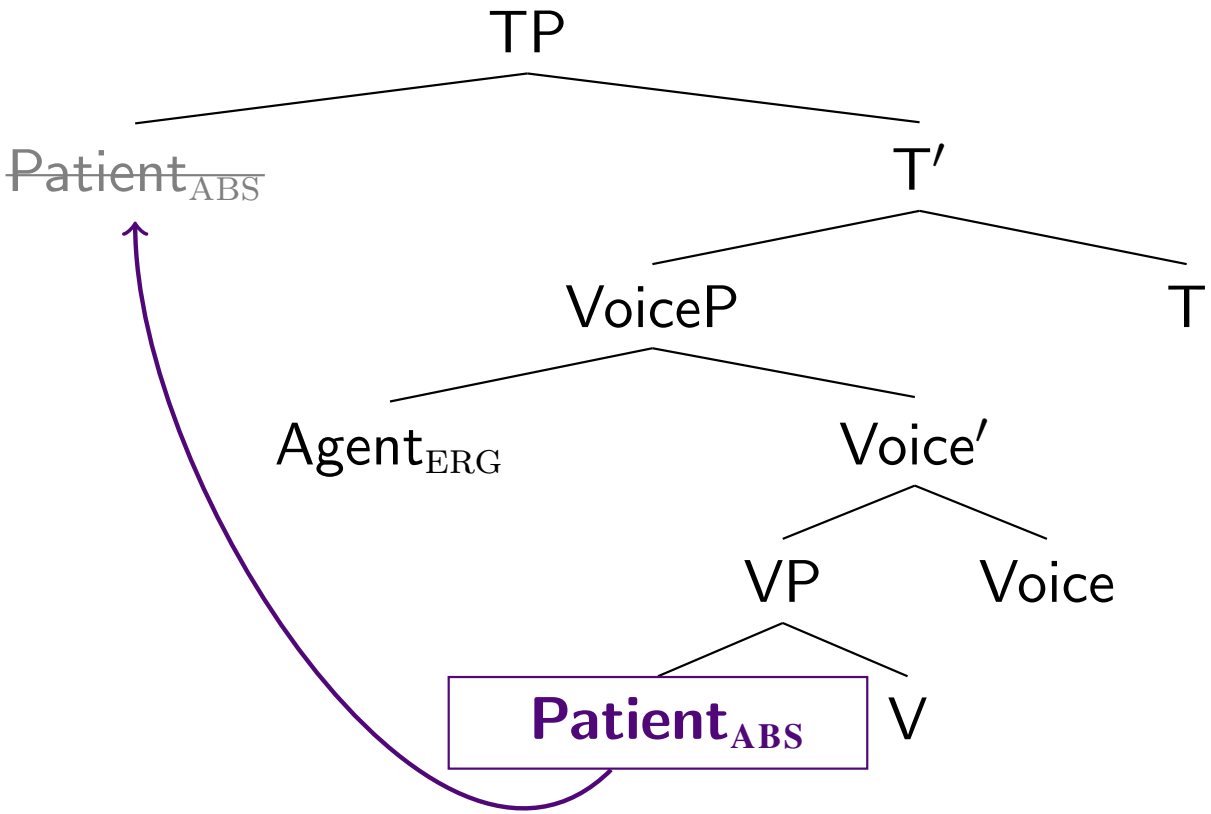
Nominalizations = verbal phrase embedded in nominal morphology

Question: how much verbal structure is there?

The problem:

- **Reciprocals:**
  Nominalizations are large enough for ABS to be the highest argument.
- **Constraints on argument incorporation:** (Ershova 2020)
  Nominalizations are sensitive to the thematic hierarchy, like reflexives and control
  $\Rightarrow$ ERG must be the highest argument.

The solution: ABS is high, but pronounced low



⇒ **/Agent- Patient- Verb/**

- ABS is syntactically high ∼ ability to bind reciprocals
- but is pronounced low ∼ rules of incorporation

Roadmap

Background on West Circassian

Syntactic ergativity in nominalizations

Argument encoding in nominalizations

The analysis: Move high, pronounce low

Conclusion

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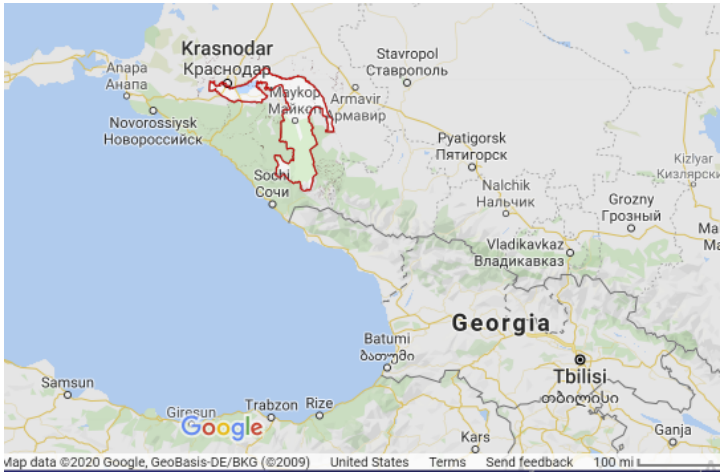
West Circassian

West Circassian (or Adyghe):

- Northwest Caucasian
- Republic of Adygea, Russia
- agglutinating, polysynthetic
- ergative case and agreement



Data:

- fieldwork on the **Temirgoy dialect** in the Shovgenovsky district of Adygea (2017-2019)
- Adyghe Corpus by Timofey Arkhangelskiy, Irina Bagirokova, Yury Lander, and Anna Lander (`http://adyghe.web-corpora.net/`)

Disclaimer: Glossing and segmentation may be simplified for exposition.

West Circassian is polysynthetic

Head marking and pro-drop:

сыкъыпфаригъэлъэгъугъ /*səqəpfarjəʁeʎeʁʷəʁ*/

me **for your sake** **to them** **he**

sə-	qə-	p-f-	a-r-	jə-	ʁe-
1SG.ABS-	DIR-	2SG.IO+BEN-	3PL.IO+DAT-	3SG.ERG-	CAUS-

λeʁʷə -ʁ

see -PST

'He showed me to them for your sake.'

(Korotkova and Lander 2010, 301)

Order of cross-reference markers:

ABS- **(IO+APPL-)*** **ERG-**

Complex nominal morphology

- complements and modifiers incorporated
- include a mix of lexical and functional morphology

цокъэ ык1и щыгъын тучанхэр

[cʷeqe- əč'jə- š'əʁən]- **tʷeč'an** -xe -r
footwear- and- clothes- shop -PL -ABS

'shops of shoes and clothes' (Lander 2017, 93)

абдзэхэ шыуищ

[abʒexe]- **šəw** -jə- š'
Abzakh- horseman -LNK- three

'three Abzakh horsemen' (Lander 2017, 83)

Phonological diagnostic for incorporation

Stem-final alternation: C**e**Ce $]_{\text{STEM}} \rightarrow$ C**a**Ce

цокъэ ык1и щыгъын тучанхэр

[c^{w}**e**qe- əč'jə- š'əʁən- **t^{w}eč'an**] -xe -r
footwear- and- clothes- shop -PL -ABS

'shops of shoes and clothes' (Lander 2017, 93)

абдзэхэ шыуищ

[abʒ**e**xe- **šəw** -jə- š']
Abzakh- horseman -LNK- three

'three Abzakh horsemen' (Lander 2017, 83)

Compare:

цуакъэхэр

[c^{w}**a**qe]-xe-r
shoe-PL-ABS

'shoes' (AC)

абдзахэмэ

[abʒ**a**xe]-me
Abzakh-PL.OBL

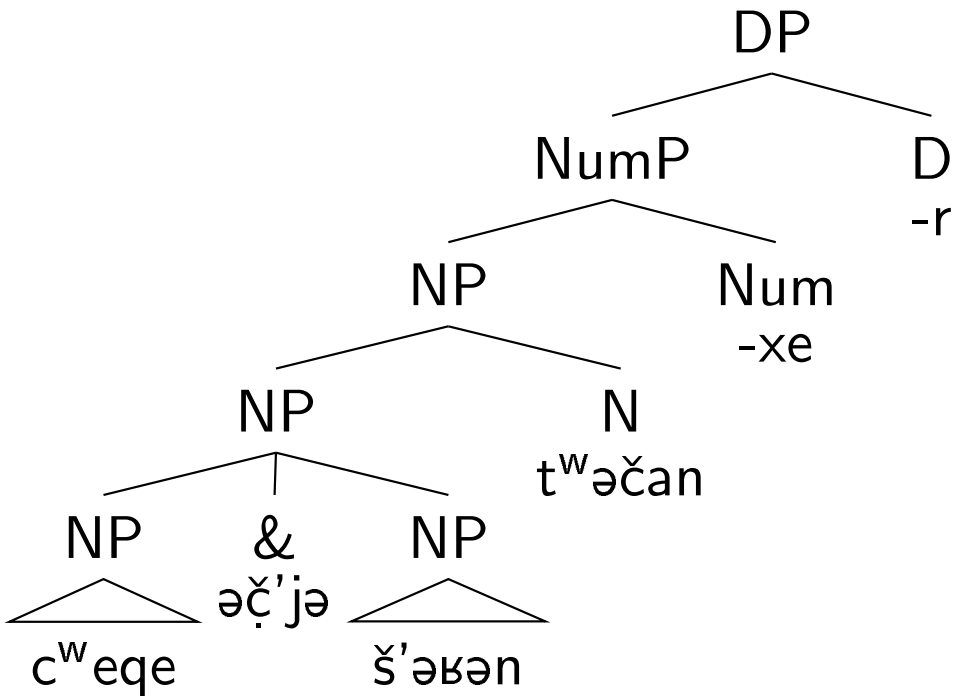
'the Abzakh' (AC)

Nominal phrase mapped to phonological word

цокъэ ык1и щыгъын тучанхэр

[cʷeqe- əčʼjə- šʼəʁən- tʷečʼan] -xe -r
footwear- and- clothes- shop -PL -ABS

‘shops of shoes and clothes’



⟶ /cʷeqe-əčʼjə-šʼəʁən-tʷəčʼan-xe-r/ (Ershova 2020)

Head marking on nominals

сшыпхъухэр

s-	šəpχ^{w}əxer
1SG.PR-	sister.PL.ABS

'my sisters' **INALIENABLE**

тигъунэгъухэм

t-	jə-	ʁ^{w}əneʁ^{w}əxem
1PL.PR-	POSS-	neighbor.PL.OBL

'our neighbors' **ALIENABLE**

Case marking

-r (ABS):

- intransitive subject
- direct object

-m (OBL):

- transitive subject
- applied object
- \+ complements of P
- \+ possessors

мы пшъашъэр дахэу къашъо

mə pŝaŝe-**r** daxew qaŝ^{w}e
this girl-**ABS** well dances

'This girl dances well.'

сабыйхэм хьахэр къалъэгъугъ

sabəjxe-**m** haxe-**r** qaλeʁ^{w}əʁ
children-**OBL** dogs-**ABS** saw

'The children saw the dogs.'

мафэ къэс еджап1эм сэк1о

mafe-qes jeǯaṗe-**m** seḳ^{w}e
day-each school-**OBL** go

'I go to school every day.'

Case marking on possessors

пшъашъэм ипшъэшъэгъу

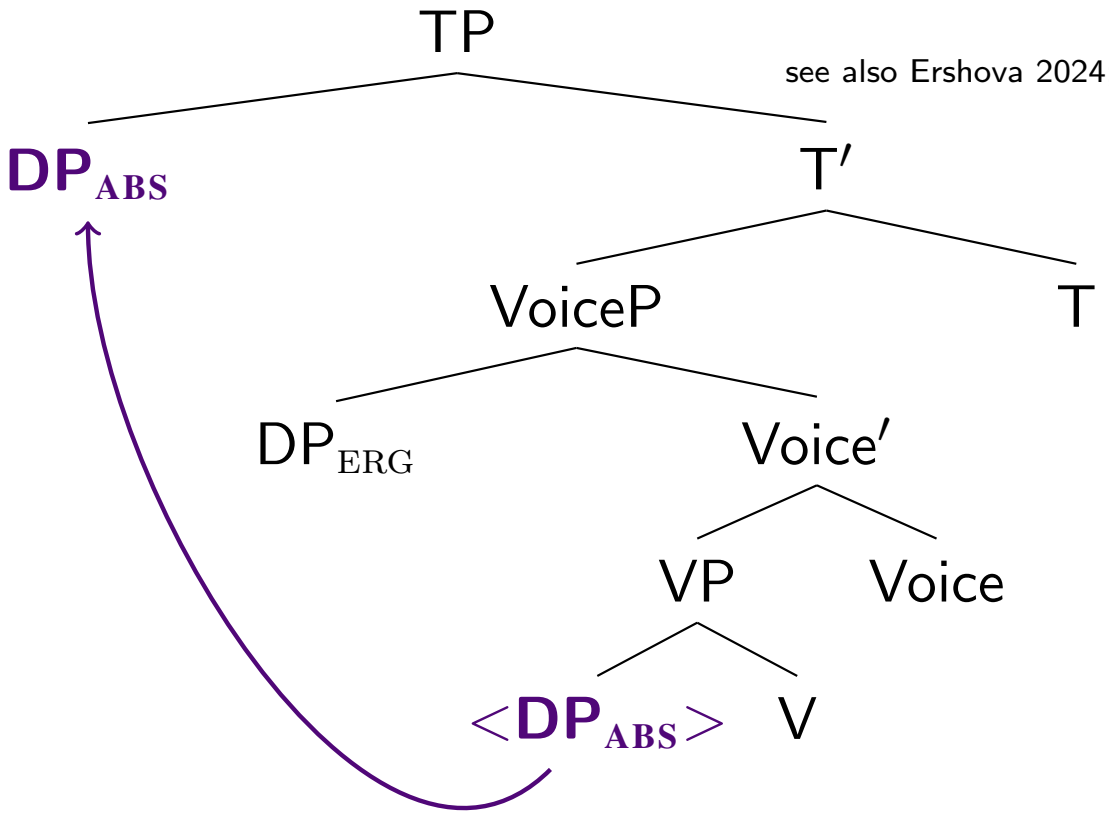
pŝaŝe-**m**	Ø-jə-pŝeŝeʁ^{w}
girl-**OBL**	3SG.PR-POSS-female.friend

'the girl's friend'

High absolutive

- ABS moves to Spec,TP
- ERG (and IO) remain in situ
- evidence from parasitic gaps and **reciprocal binding**

(Ershova 2019, 2021, 2023;
see also Ershova 2024; Lander 2009, 2012; Letuchiy 2010)



(Aldridge 2008; Baker 1997; Bittner and Hale 1996; Manning 1996; Yuan 2018, 2022;
Coon, Baier, and T. Levin 2021; Royer 2025, a.o.)

Reciprocals in West Circassian

Reciprocals are covert and trigger **reciprocal agreement** on the predicate:

- correlates with syntactic position of the reciprocal
- does not affect transitivity ⇒ not a de-transitivizing operator (Appendix A)

Reciprocals are subject to Condition A

= must be bound by a structurally higher antecedent

(Ershova 2019, 2023)

Reciprocal agreement

ABS agentive S binds **IO**
⇒ REC replaces IO agreement

шъукъыддэшъощт

you **with us**

ŝʷə-	qə-	**d-**	de-	ŝʷešʼt
2PL.ABS-	DIR-	1PL.IO-	COM-	dance.FUT

BASELINE

'You(pl) will dance with us'

Reciprocal agreement

ABS agentive S binds **IO**
⇒ REC replaces IO agreement

шъукъызэдэшъощт

you **with each other**

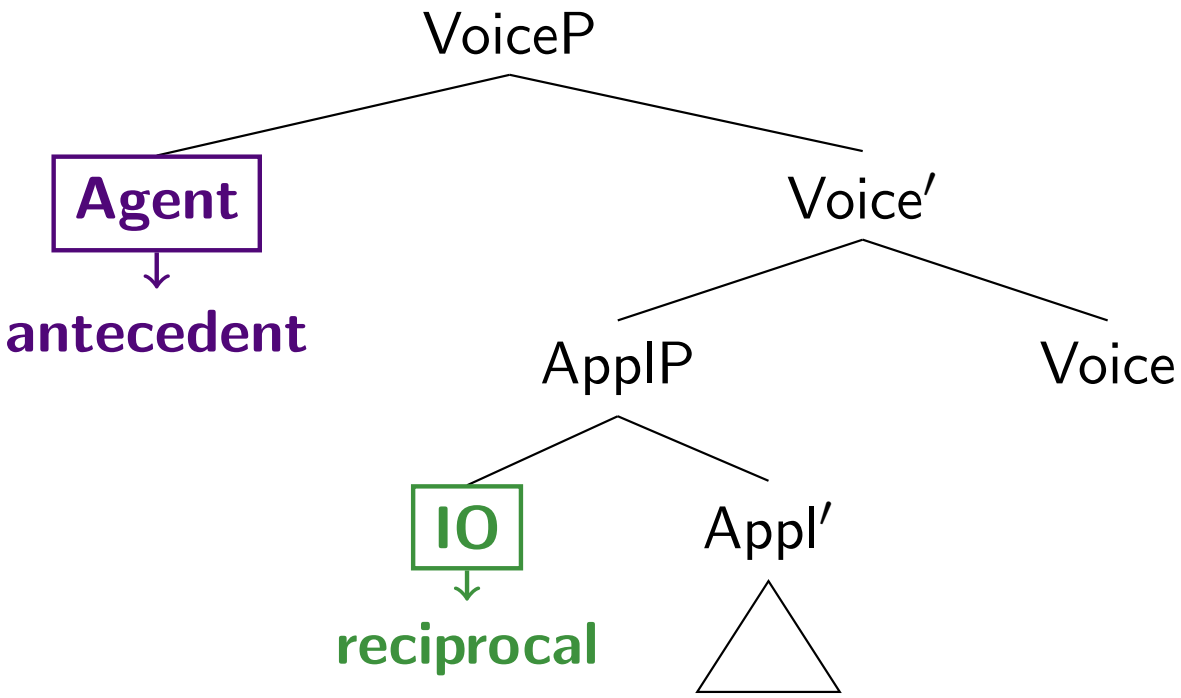
ŝʷə-	qə-	**ze-**	de-	ŝʷešʼt
2PL.ABS-	DIR-	REC.IO-	COM-	dance.FUT

RECIPROCAL

'You(pl) will dance with each other'

Reciprocal binding reveals argument asymmetries

ABS/**ERG** agent binds **IO**:

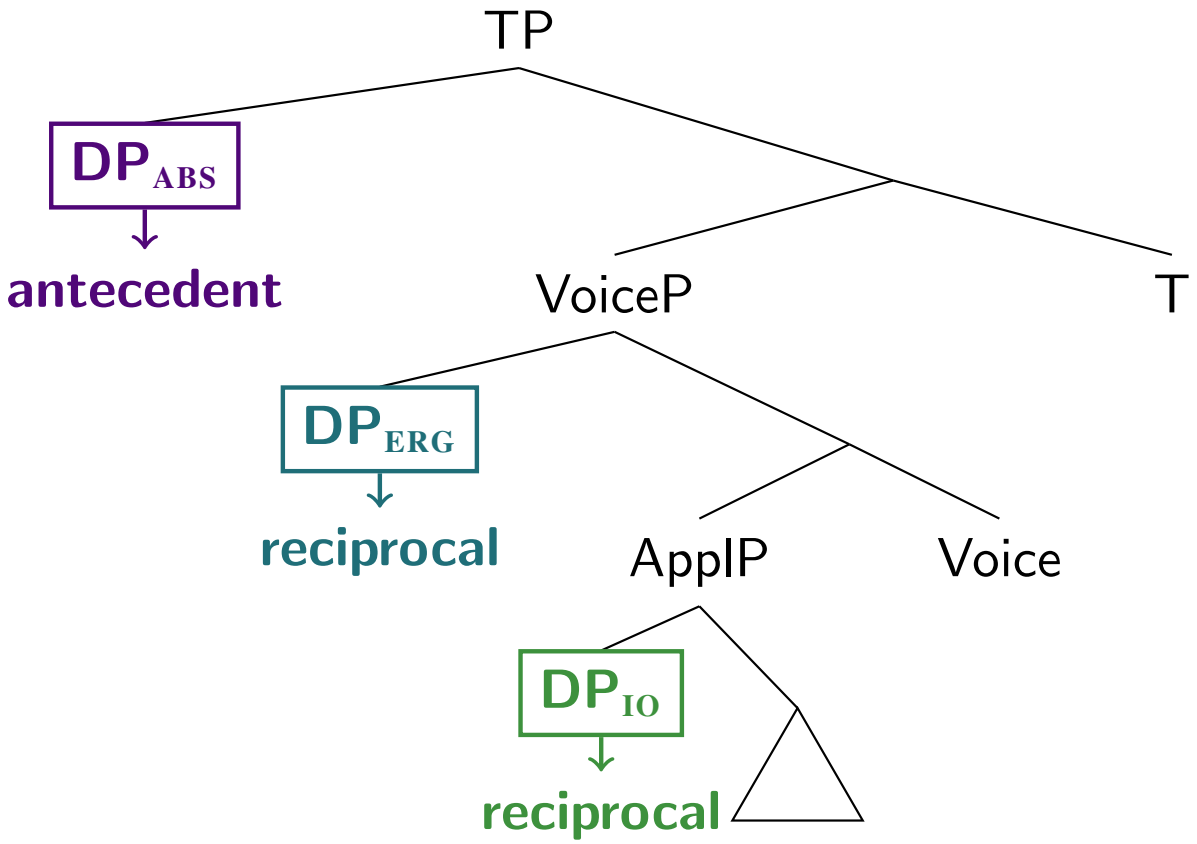


Correlates with agent being higher (=c-commanding) IO.

Syntactic ergativity in reciprocal binding

Reciprocals provide evidence for ABS being the highest argument (≈ subject-like):

- reciprocals are bound by a c-commanding antecedent
- **ABS** binds **ERG** and **IO** $\boxed{\Rightarrow \textbf{ABS} \text{ c-commands } \textbf{ERG} \text{ and } \textbf{IO}}$



High ABS binds IO

тызэфищагъ

us	each other			
tə-	ze-	f-	jə-	š'aʁ
1PL.ABS-	REC.IO-	BEN-	3SG.ERG-	bring.PST

'S/he brought us together (= to each other).'

Literally: 'S/he brought each other us.'

IO cannot bind high ABS

*зэтфищагъ

each other us

*ze-	t-	f-	jə-	š’aʁ
REC.ABS-	1PL.IO-	BEN-	3SG.ERG-	bring.PST

Literally: ‘S/he brought us each other.’

High ABS binds ERG

шъутлъэгъугъ

you **we**

↓ ↓

ŝʷə- **t-** λeʁʷəʁ

2PL.ABS- 1PL.ERG- see.PST

'We saw you(pl).'

BASELINE

High ABS binds ERG

тызэрэлъэгъугъ

we each other

tə- zere- λeʁʷəʁ

1PL.ABS- REC.ERG- see.PST

lit. ‘Each other saw us.’

RECIPROCAL

Obligatory high ABS: ERG cannot bind ABS

*зэрэтлъэгъугъ

each other we

*zere- t- λeʁʷəʁ

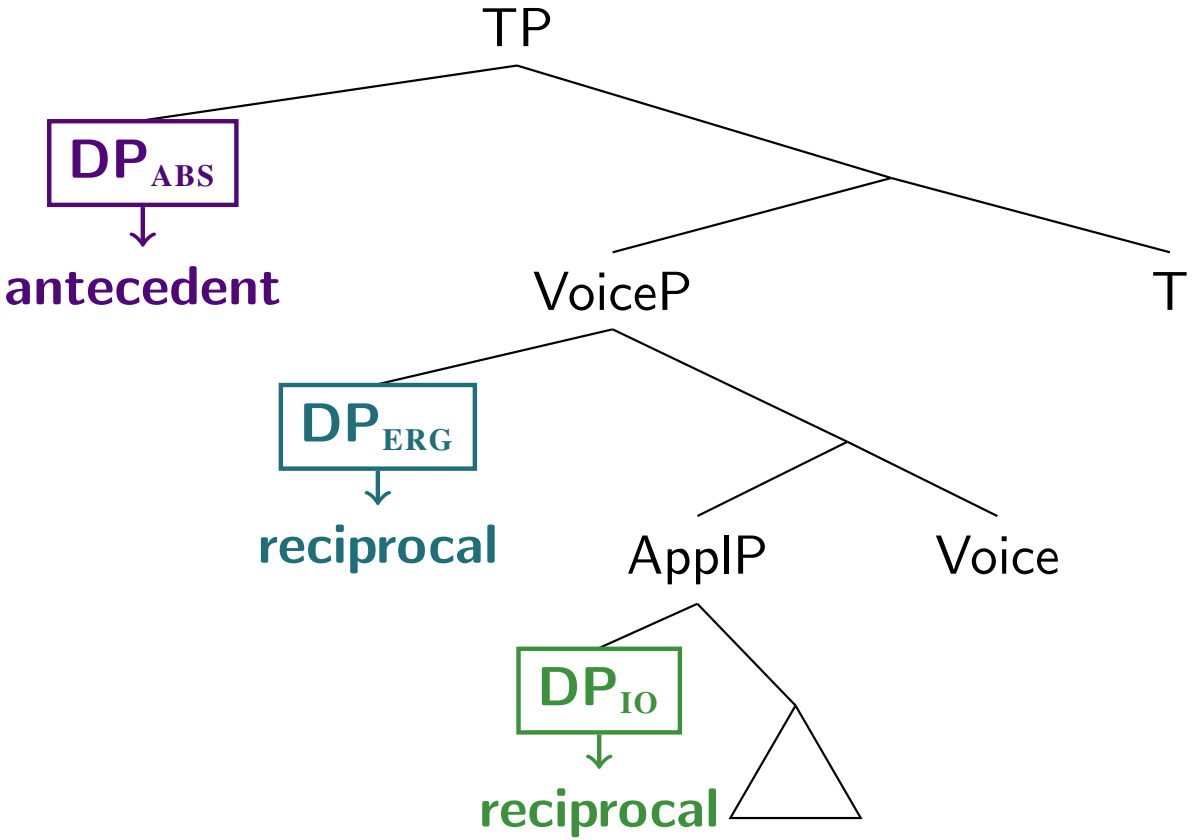
REC.ABS- 1PL.ERG- see.PST

*ABS = REC

Intended: 'We saw each other.'

Reciprocals: summary

West Circassian displays syntactic ergativity in reciprocal binding:
ABS binds ERG and IO ⇒ **ABS is higher than ERG and IO**



Basic clause structure: summary

West Circassian:

- polysynthetic: head marking and complex morphology
- ergative case marking and agreement
- ABS displays subject-like properties $\sim$ syntactic ergativity

Roadmap

Background on West Circassian

Syntactic ergativity in nominalizations

Argument encoding in nominalizations

The analysis: Move high, pronounce low

Conclusion

Diagnosing verbal structure in nominalizations

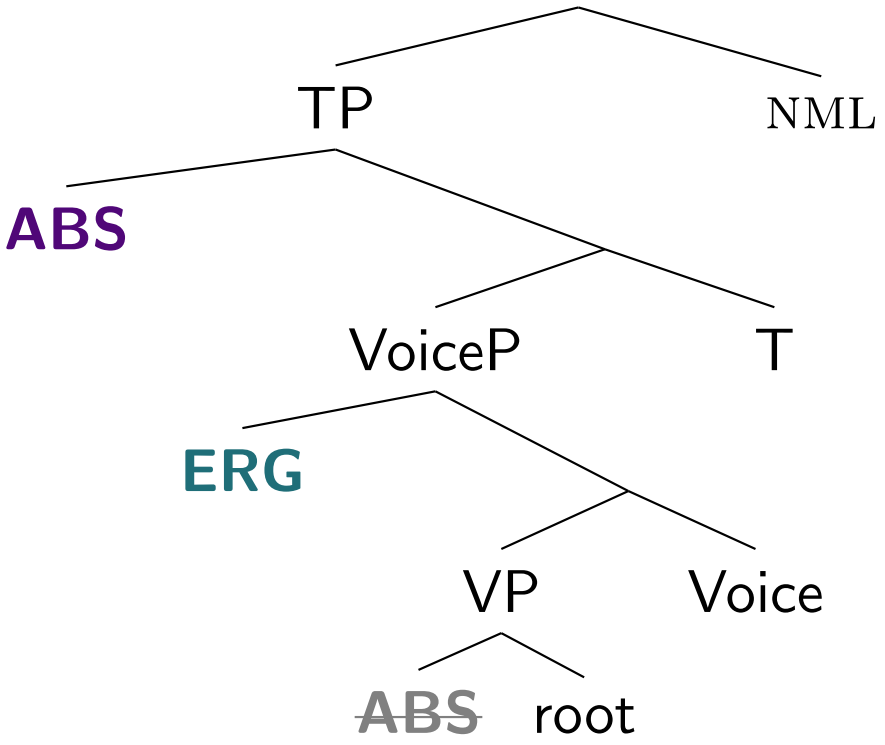
Nominalization = (some) verbal functional structure embedded under nominal functional structure

The standard question

- **How much** verbal structure is included in the nominalization,
- and **how is this reflected** in the morphosyntax (and semantics) of the resulting construction?

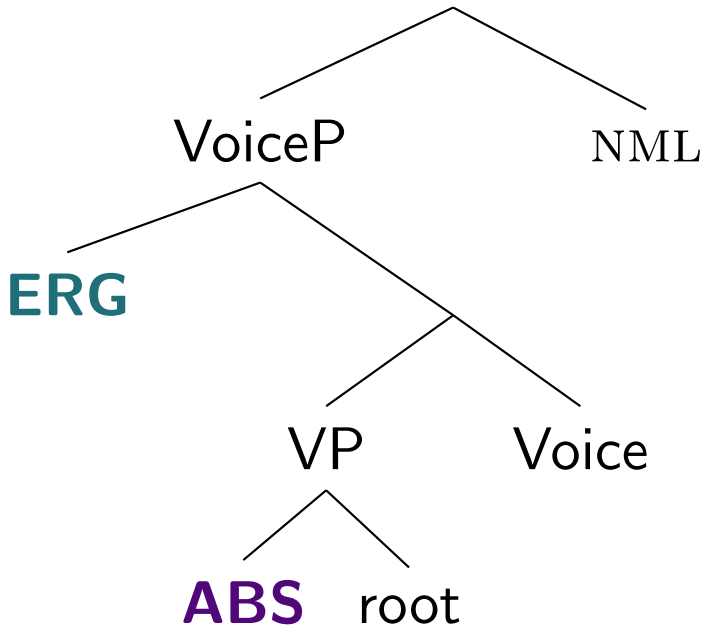
West Circassian nominalizations: The prediction

Nominalization includes TP
$\Rightarrow$ high ABS



$\Rightarrow$ ABS is subject-like

Does not include TP
$\Rightarrow$ low ABS



$\Rightarrow$ thematic hierarchy: ERG>ABS
(cf. reflexives and control)

The puzzle and the proposal

The puzzle: contradictory argument asymmetries

- ABS binds ERG and IO reciprocals $\Rightarrow$ ABS is highest
- argument incorporation constrained by thematic heirarchy $\Rightarrow$ ERG is highest

The solution: ABS is syntactically high, but pronounced low

Reminder: Noun phrase structure

- cross-reference marking for the possessor
- complements and modifiers incorporated

тишэн-хэбзэ дахэхэр

tjə-	**še-n-**	xebze	**-daxe**	-xe	-r
1PL.POSS-	**lead-NML-**	rule	**-beautiful**	-PL	-ABS

'our beautiful rules of conduct' (Ershova 2020, 431)

Nominal properties of nominalizations

Ershova (2020)

- arguments as possessors or incorporated
  ⇒no verbal licensing/case
- no verbal cross-reference marking
  → possessor ϕ-marking

лагъэхэр сэтхьак1ы

laʁe-xe-r	**Ø-**	**s-**	e-	thač̣'ə	**FINITE**
dish-PL-ABS	**3ABS-**	**1SG.ERG-**	DYN-	wash	

'I am washing dishes.'

уилэгъэ тхьак1ык1э

wjə-	**leʁe-**	thač̣'ə	-č̣'e	**NOMINALIZATION**
2SG.POSS-	**dish-**	wash	-NML	

'your manner of washing dishes'

Clause-like properties of nominalizations

- (some) adverbial modifiers (Appendix B)
- some cross-reference marking and associated morphology
- high absolutive syntax: ABS can bind ERG reciprocal

Verbal cross-reference morphology in nominalizations

- full verbal cross-reference marking is not available
- but other morphemes that are associated and intersperced with cross-reference marking are present
- reciprocal (and reflexive) cross-reference marking is possible

Evidence for:

- nominalizations are large: include almost full clause
- reciprocals: evidence for **high absolutive**

Cross-reference-adjacent morphology is retained

"Directional" prefix *qe-*:

тыкъигъэк1ыжь

tə-	**q-**	**jə-**	ʁe-č'ə-ž'
1PL.ABS-	**DIR-**	**3SG.ERG-**	CAUS-rise-again

's/he raised us again' **FINITE**

икъэгъэк1ын

jə-	**qe-**	ʁe-č'ə-n
3SG.POSS-	**DIR-**	CAUS-rise-NML

'its raising' (http://adyghe.web-corpora.net/) **NOMINALIZATION**

Cross-reference-adjacent morphology is retained

Applicative prefix:

шъхьэк1афэ афиш1ыщтыгъ

ŝheč’afe	**Ø-**	**a-**	**f-**	**jə-**	ŝə-š’təʁ
respect	**3ABS-**	**3PL.IO-**	**BEN-**	**3SG.ERG-**	do-IPF.PST

‘He was showing respect for them.’ **FINITE**

пщы шъхьэк1эфэ фэш1ык1э

pš’ə-	ŝheč’efe-	**fe-**	ŝə-č’e
prince-	respect-	**BEN-**	do-NML

‘showing respect for princes’ **NOMINALIZATION**

(http://adyghe.web-corpora.net/)

Nominalizations allow anaphor agreement

- reciprocal agreement **with applicative**

ахэр зэфэгу1эжьых

axer	Ø-	**ze-f-**	e-	gʷəʔežʼə	-x
they.ABS	3ABS-	**REC.IO-BEN-**	DYN-	endeavor	-PL

'They work hard for each other.' **FINITE**

яззэфэгу1эжьык1э

ja-	**ze-fe-**	gʷəʔežʼə	-c̣ʼe
3PL.POSS-	**REC.IO-BEN-**	endeavor	-NML

'their manner of working hard for each other' **NOMINALIZATION**

Nominalizations allow anaphor agreement

- reciprocal agreement **with ergative**

$\Rightarrow$ DP_{ABS} binds DP_{ERG}
$\Rightarrow$**high absolutive!**

къэзэрэгъэшъожьых

Ø-	qe-	zer-	e-	ʁe-	ŝʷe	-ž'ə	-x
3ABS-	DIR-	REC.ERG-	DYN-	CAUS-	dance	-RE	-PL

'They are making each other dance.' **FINITE**

якъэзэрэгъэшъуак1э

ja-	qe-	zere-	ʁe-	ŝʷa	-č̣'e
3PL.POSS-	DIR-	REC.ERG-	CAUS-	dance	-NML

'their manner of making each other dance' **NOMINALIZATION**

Syntactic ergativity in nominalizations: summary

Nominalizations include:

- adverbial modifiers
- structure associated with cross-reference marking
- enough clausal structure that **ABS moves high**

Next: If ABS is high, why is argument order constrained based on the thematic hierarchy?

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Constraint on argument encoding

Strict order of arguments (Ershova 2020)

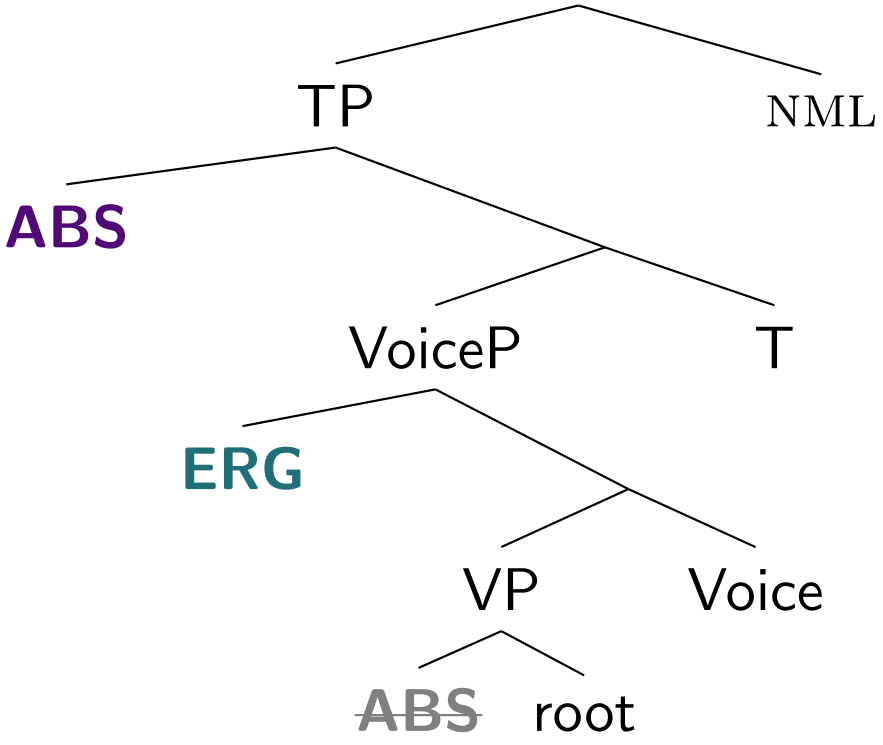
The **less agentive argument** must appear closer to the verbal root than the **more agentive argument**.

- 2-place intransitives: **ABS- IO-** root
- Transitives: **ERG- ABS-** root

Contrary to prediction of high ABS:
ERG and IO should appear closer to the root than ABS.

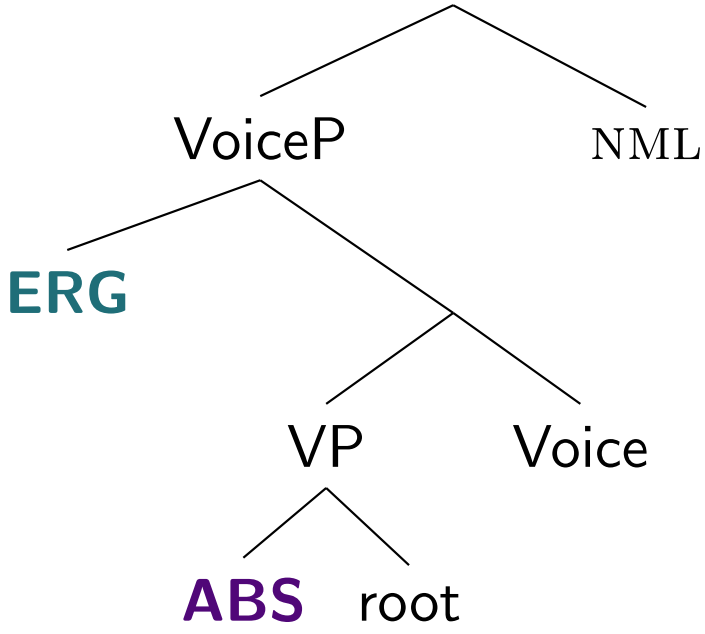
Argument order: High ABS prediction visualized

Nominalization includes TP
$\Rightarrow$ high ABS



$\Rightarrow$ * **ABS- ERG-** root -NML

Does not include TP
$\Rightarrow$ low ABS



$\Rightarrow$ ✓ **ERG- ABS-** root -NML

ABS Agent appears farther from root than IO

мы пшъашъэр хьак1эмэ яжэ

mə pŝaŝe-r**(ABS)** hač'e-me**(IO)** Ø-ja-že
this girl-ABS guest-PL.OBL 3ABS-3PL.IO+DAT-wait
'This girl is waiting for guests.'

хак1эмэ япшъэшъэ ежап1э

hač'e-me**(ABS)** ja-pŝeŝe**(IO)**-je-ža-ṗe
guest-PL.OBL 3PL.POSS-girl-DAT-wait-NML
'the place for the guests' waiting for the girl'
not: *'the place for the girls' waiting for the guests' (Ershova 2020, 463)

ABS-IO verb: Order of arguments

AGENT(ABS) – **IO** – Root

* **IO** – **AGENT(ABS)** – Root

ERG Agent appears farther from root than ABS theme

мы пшъашъэм лагъэхэр етхьак1ы

mə pŝaŝe-m(**ERG**) laʁe-xe-r(**ABS**) Ø-j-e-thač'ə
this girl-ABS dish-PL-ABS 3ABS-3SG.ERG-DYN-wash

'This girl is washing the dishes.'

пшъэшъэ лэгъэ тхьак1ык1эр
#**лэгъэ пшъэшъэ тхьак1ык1эр**

	ERG-	**ABS-**			
✓	**pŝeŝe-**	**leʁe-**	thač'ə	-č'e	-r
	girl-	**dish-**	wash	-NML	-ABS

	ABS-	**ERG-**			
#	**leʁe-**	**pŝeŝe-**	thač'ə	-č'e	-r
	dish-	**girl-**	wash	-NML	ABS

'the girls' manner of dish-washing' (Ershova 2020, 461-462)

ERG-ABS verb: Order of arguments

ERG–**ABS**–Root

* **ABS**–**ERG**–Root

Summary: Argument encoding follows thematic hierarchy

- **Reciprocals:** nominalizations are syntactically ergative

  ABS(AGENT/THEME) > ERG(AGENT) > IO(GOAL/ETC.)

- **But:** argument encoding in nominalizations is sensitive to the thematic hierarchy

  ABS(AGENT) > IO(GOAL/ETC.)

  $\boxed{\text{ERG(AGENT)} > \text{ABS(THEME)}}$

- If nominalizations are large enough for high ABS, why this constraint on arguments?

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The proposal in a nutshell

ABS moves high, but is pronounced low **to be licensed**.

In a nutshell:

- Nominal arguments must be licensed.
- **Option 1:** Through case or agreement (≈ Case Filter)

  (Branan 2022; Kalin 2019; T. F. Levin 2015; Nie 2024)
- **Option 2:** By adjacency to selecting head (T. F. Levin 2015)
  (If case/agreement is not available.)

In a full clause, arguments are assigned case by verbal heads.

In a nominalization, only 1 case is available (possessor).

Only other option: adjacency.

Licensing by adjacency

An NP is **licensed by adjacency** iff

- NP is pronounced as part of the same phonological word as the head that assigns its theta-role, and
- NP is pronounced adjacent to (the projection of) the head that selects it.

$\Rightarrow$ Caseless NPs must appear in their base position.

ABS moves high, but is pronounced low.

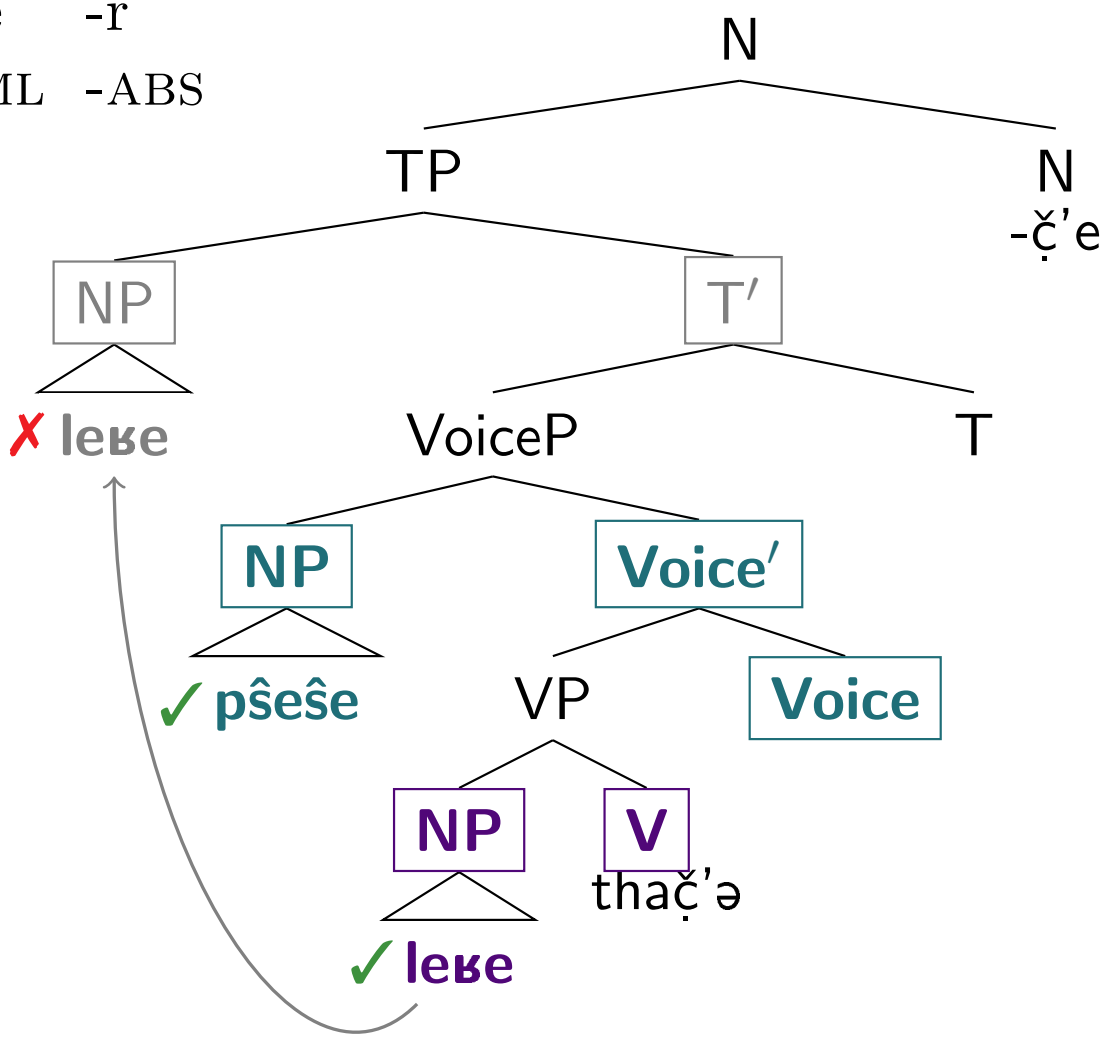
Licensing by adjacency vs. high ABS

пшъэшъэ лэгъэ тхьак1ык1эр

pŝeŝe- leʁe- thač̣'ə -č̣'e -r

girl- dish- wash -NML -ABS

'girls' dish-washing'



Licensing by adjacency $\neq$ VoiceP-level hierarchy

Reflexives are sensitive to the 'thematic hierarchy':

- Agent(ERG) > Theme(ABS)
- Agent(ABS) > Goal/location/...(IO)

So far, licensing by adjacency works the same way.

However: difference with "inverse" predicates

Inverse predicates

- Small set of psych predicates: **IO** experiencer + **ABS** theme
- Reflexives: **IO** and **ABS** are symmetrical
- Nominalizations: **IO** > **ABS**

Reflexives with inverse predicates

сыпщыгъупшагъ

THEME-	**EXP-**		
sə-	**p-**	š’ə-	ʁʷəpšaʁ
1SG.ABS-	**2SG.IO-**	LOC-	forget.PST

‘You forgot about me.’

зысщыгъупшэжьыгъ

zə-	**s-**	š’ə-	ʁʷəpšež’əʁ	**EXPERIENCER** > **THEME**
REFL.ABS-	**1SG.IO-**	LOC-	forget.RE.PST	

сызщыгъупшэжьыгъ

sə-	**z-**	š’ə-	ʁʷəpšež’əʁ	**THEME** > **EXPERIENCER**
1SG.ABS-	**REFL.IO-**	LOC-	forget.RE.PST	

‘I forgot about myself.’ (Ershova 2023, 224)

Nominalizations of inverse predicates

к1алэм инэнэ щыгъупшэн

ḉ'ale-m(IO) jə-nene(ABS)-š'ə-ʁ^{w}əpše-n
boy-OBL 3SG.POSS-grandmother-LOC-forget-NML

'the boy's forgetting of grandmothers'

not: *'grandmothers' forgetting of the boy' (Ershova 2020, 464)

Inverse IO-ABS verb: Order of arguments

EXPERIENCER(IO) – THEME(ABS) – Root

* THEME(ABS) – EXPERIENCER(IO) – Root

Adjacency $\neq$ VoiceP-level hierarchy

Inverse verbs provide evidence for two distinct hierarchies:

- VoiceP-level: **EXPERIENCER** and **THEME** are symmetrical

  $\Rightarrow$ symmetry derived through movement

- Licensing by adjacency: **EXPERIENCER** $>$ **THEME**

  $\Rightarrow$ reveals underlying thematic hierarchy

Confirms: Analyzing nominalizations as being smaller (e.g. including just VoiceP) would not explain argument order.

PLUS, reciprocal binding would remain unexplained.

High ABS+ licensing by adjacency is a better explanation:

ABS moves high, but is pronounced low.

Roadmap

Background on West Circassian

Syntactic ergativity in nominalizations

Argument encoding in nominalizations

The analysis: Move high, pronounce low

Conclusion

Conclusion: where you're pronounced is not where you are

West Circassian nominalizations present a puzzle:

- According to reciprocal binding, **ABS** > **ERG**.
- According to rules of argument incorporation: **ERG** > **ABS**.

The solution: ABS moves high, but is pronounced low.

- **ABS** can bind **ERG** from high position.
- **ABS** is pronounced lower than **ERG** to be licensed.

Thank you!

- West Circassian consultants: Svetlana K. Alishaeva, Saida Gisheva, Susana K. Khatkova, and Zarema Meretukova
- Audiences at: GLOW 46, UMass, and the Hungarian Research Centre for Linguistics
- Funding sources for data collection:
  - Dissertation Research Improvement Grant from the National Science Foundation (BCS-1749299)
  - Andrew W. Mellon Fellowship of Scholars in the Humanities at Stanford University

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Reciprocal agreement does not affect transitivity

ERG binds **IO**

- REC replaces IO agreement
- ERG antecedent bears ERG case

ахэмэ 1эгубжъэр зэратыжьы

axe-**me**	ʔegʷəbẑe-r	Ø-	**ze-**	r-	**a-**	təž'ə
that.PL-**ERG**	cup-ABS	3ABS-	**REC.IO-**	DAT-	**3PL.ERG-**	give

'They pass the cup to each other.'

(http://adyghe.web-corpora.net/)

Reciprocal agreement does not affect transitivity

ABS binds **IO**

- REC replaces IO agreement
- ABS antecedent bears ABS case

сабыйхэр зэплъыжьых

sabəjxe**-r**	Ø-	**z-**	e-	pλəž'əx
child.PL**-ABS**	3ABS-	**REC.IO-**	DAT-	look.PL

'The children are looking at each other.'

Some adverbial modifiers are possible

- temporal modifiers
- CP-sized adjunct clauses

Nominalizations include temporal adverbs

мафэ къэс уитучан к1он сезэщыгъ

[**mafe-qes**	wjə-	tʷəčan-	ḳʷe	-n]	sjezeš'əʁ
day-each	2SG.POSS-	store-	go	-NML	I am tired

'I'm tired of your going to the store every day.'

Compare with non-derived nouns:

***мафэ къэс передач**

* **mafe-qes**	pjerjedač
day-each	broadcast

Intended: 'everyday program'

Concessive clausal adjunct in nominalization

сыгу рехьы илэгъэ тхьак1ык1э псы щымы1эми

səg^{w}	rjehə	[jə-	leʁe-	thač̣’ə	-č̣’e	
I like		3SG.POSS-	dish-	wash	-NML	
[**psə**	**š’əmə?emjə**]]					
water	despite not having					

‘I like his/her washing the dishes despite not having water.’

Manner clausal adjunct in nominalization

сыгу рихьырэп иахъщэ гъэк1уак1э неущре мафэм имыгупщысэу

səg^{w}	rjəhərep	[jə-	aχš'e-	ʁe-	ḳ^{w}a	-č̣'e	
I don't like		3SG.POSS-	money-	CAUS-	go	-NML	
[**njewəš'remafem**		**jeməg^{w}əpšəsew**]]					
tomorrow		not thinking					

'I don't like his manner of spending money without thinking about tomorrow.'